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LAW AND DISORDER Factory workers protest in Noida, Apr. 13

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UNREST OVER WAGES

A surge of protests across industrial clusters highlights mounting anger over low wages, inadequate social security and denial of basic workplace rights

By SONAL KHETARPAL

WHAT BEGAN AS A MINOR FLARE-UP AT A STATE-OWNED REFINERY in Bihar in February has spread into a wider wave of labour unrest. Across several parts of industrial India, thousands of workers—contractual, temporary and migrant—have taken to the streets. Their strikingly similar demands expose strains in the country's industrial system: higher minimum wages in line with the rising cost of living, social security benefits such as provident fund and Employees' State Insurance, better working conditions, weekly offs, overtime pay and basic amenities like toilets.

The first burst of discontent appeared in February near the Indian Oil Corporation refinery in Barauni, in Bihar's Begusarai district. Similar protests soon surfaced at the company's Panipat refinery in Haryana, before spreading to Manesar in the same state, then to Noida and Ghaziabad in Uttar Pradesh, and more recently to Surat in Gujarat, Bhiwadi in Rajasthan and Haldwani in Uttarakhand.